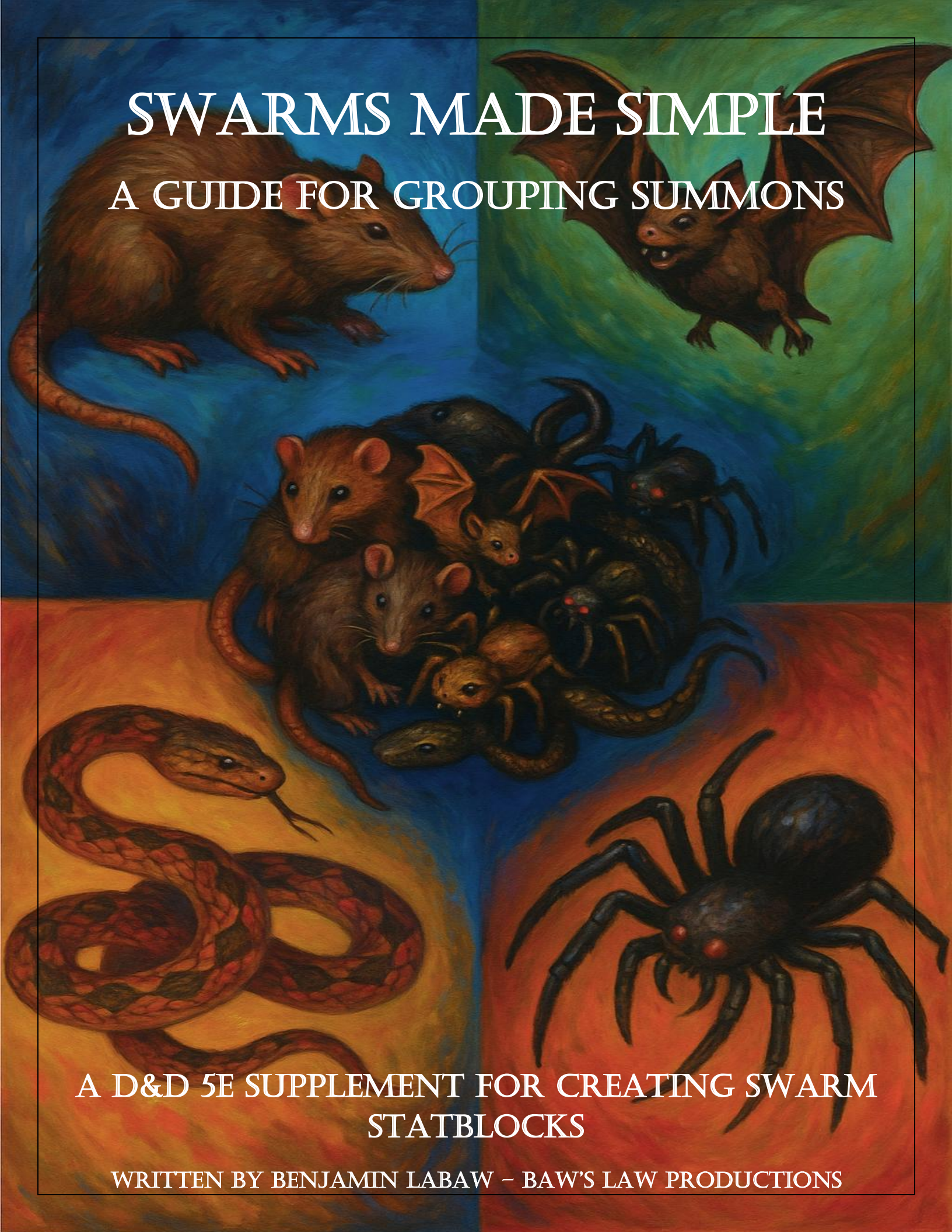




SWARMS MADE SIMPLE

A GUIDE FOR GROUPING SUMMONS

A D&D 5E SUPPLEMENT FOR CREATING SWARM
STATBLOCKS

WRITTEN BY BENJAMIN LABAW – BAW'S LAW PRODUCTIONS

Swarms Made Simple

A Guide for Grouping Summons, A D&D 5e Supplement



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Typical Trouble

How do separated summons slow down gameplay to a snail's pace?

Simplified Solutions

Rules to clump separate beasts into single statblocks.

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Sample Statblocks

Examples of common summons and how they would look after the "Swarms Made Simple" process!

Introduction

By Benjamin LaBaw

The Druid, brushing aside tangled sticks in her hair, raises her hands to flick her wrists. Everyone knows what is coming...a powerful spell that will wreck the battlefield. Is it a creative polymorph, or perhaps a vicious storm? Nope, everyone groans as she shouts "I summon eight gorillas to my aid"!

What was once a crisp combat now slows to a halt. The Druid's turn takes twice as long, taking away the spotlight from other players. People are losing interest fast...and the Dungeon Master is desperate to get control of the situation. If only there were a way to overcome this extreme diversion?!

Enter *Swarms Made Simple*, a 5e supplement that gives a quick and easy blueprint for grouping enemies! This product is the key to quickly organizing summoned creatures into an organized statblock. Say goodbye to the woes of slow combat: *Swarms Made Simple* is a solution for endless summons.

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For compatibility purposes, this module is designed for use with the 5th Edition of the world's most popular tabletop roleplaying game.

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Preface

We were expert players, veterans of multiple campaigns with many twists and turns. It was not a surprise that our combats went quickly! But my eyes opened the first time I saw summoning attempted...eight different creatures with separate initiatives. Combat slowed to a crawl!

No matter how much experience a table has, this remains an issue. Some groups avoid summoning styles altogether...that does not seem fair to players though! There must be a way to keep this playstyle relevant. *Why* does summoning slow down gameplay so much, and *how* can it be modified to ease these issues?

Ever since I started serving as Dungeon Master in 2018, I wanted to make it easy to access this wonderful game. Most people do not have the time or patience to modify the standard rules to remove issues. Yet very little content is available to bridge this gap.

Enter ***Swarms Made Simple***, the second addition to my collection of D&D 5e supplements. I want this collection to be an accessible, interesting, and memorable collection of helpful rules. They should be easy to set up, yet interesting to run for new players and veterans alike!

Setting these up takes me time and inspiration. Above all else, I think back to my previous experiences as player and Dungeon Master to shape these rulesets. Even short modules deserve variation in decision making to apply the incredibly diverse playstyles that have graced our tabletop gatherings.



My inspiration for specific content comes from mixed sources. I take great inspiration from official D&D content. Plenty of modules have custom swarm statblocks already built into their bestiary! It appears entirely possible to create a consistent framework for turning separate creatures into a singular coalition on the battlefield.

Secondly, an enjoyment of customizing statblocks drove me to create this collection. I spent much of my days developing unique creatures for homebrew campaigns. Whether it be a big boss, or many minions, having organized statblocks is the easiest way to keep combat consistent! There is an excellent opportunity to address a major issue that slows D&D to a pace like sludge.

Swarms Made Simple, among other content in my collection, aims to combine these factors in a single short document that all levels of players can utilize. Some aspects take advantage of present statblocks; an enemy's abilities should still reflect in a swarm. However, fixing the issue requires innovation. Shared initiative and scaling attacks streamline swarms to make combat quick. Every rule has a purpose but should be simple to implement in any campaign setting.

I sincerely hope that you take great joy in this mini-module. I've spent a ton of time engaging with my friends using homemade materials, laughing around tables or in discord calls. Nothing would make me happier than doing the same for a community who has a burning passion for this hobby. Turn your cluttered combat into organic order with ***Swarms Made Simple***!

Chapter One

Sample Swarm

We cannot create a custom ruleset without first understanding the aspects that make a swarm in the first place. So here is a sample! The classic “Swarm of Insects”. There are several base aspects that are common sense for swarms:

1. **Hit Points.** Increased compared to base creature.
2. **Damage.** Increased compared to base creature.
3. **Size.** Increased compared to base creature.

Therefore, the 1st principle of swarm-making is to **increase relevant basic stats**. This is not the only aspect that makes a swarm effective though. You can see below that there are two unique features present:

1. **Swarm.** Feature gained when multiple creatures combine.
2. **Attack Scaling.** Damage decreases with reduced HP.

Therefore, the 2nd principle is to add abilities that make it feel like **the enemy is a horde**. Unique aspects, like Swarm-Specific Abilities, will be covered later.

SWARM OF INSECTS

Medium swarm of tiny beasts, unaligned

Armor Class 12 (Natural Armor)

Hit Points 22 (5d8)

Speed 20 ft., climb 20 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
3 (-4)	13 (+1)	10 (+0)	1 (-5)	7 (-2)	1 (-5)

Damage Resistance Bludgeoning, Piercing, Slashing

Condition Immunities Charmed, Frightened, Grappled, Paralyzed, Petrified, Prone, Restrained, Stunned

Senses Blindsight 10 Ft., passive Perception 8

Challenge 1/2 (100 XP)

Swarm. The swarm can occupy another creature's space and vice versa, and the swarm can move through any opening large enough for a Tiny insect. The swarm can't regain hit points or gain temporary hit points.

ACTIONS

Bites (swarm has more than half HP). *Melee Weapon Attack:* +3 to hit, reach 0 ft., one target in the swarm's space. *Hit:* (4d4) piercing damage.

Bites (swarm has half HP or less). *Melee Weapon Attack:* +3 to hit, reach 0 ft., one target in the swarm's space. *Hit:* (2d4) piercing damage.

Chapter Two

The Core Principles

In principle, creating a swarm relies on lumping together multiple unique enemies into a single, shared, statblock. We described three core principles listed below:

1. ***Increase Relevant Basic Stats***
2. ***Add Unique Abilities***
3. ***Apply Swarm-Specific Stats***

The end goal is to create a statblock that reflects the individuality of the core monster...but truly makes it feel streamlined to have multiple acting within the same turn. But HOW do we take action to achieve the core principles? This section will show the specific steps to make a Simple Swarm emerge!

Identifying Upgrades

I have included a table below of the basic “stats” that should be adjusted for every swarm you create:

Stat	Description
Size	How much space a creature owns (Medium->5ft Square)
Hit Points	Total amount of damage a creature can take
To Hit Bonus	The bonus added when trying to break through an enemy's armor class
Attack Damage	How much damage is actually done upon a hit

This combination of features makes the most sense to increase. Each reflects the addition of multiple creatures to help scale to a balanced statblock. At minimum, every swarm should be adjusted for these features above.

I note that there are other stats I considered for “basic” increases. These include armor class, number of attacks, and more. I decided against including these for one reason: **I felt they strongly slowed gameplay OR unbalanced the intended original monster.** But feel free to scale other stats if you feel they will flow well!



Buffing the Basics

Now that we know which basics meet our criteria, it is time to buff them! We will go Stat by Stat to show how best to simple and quickly adjust...with fair rules that do not scale out of control. Here are the important steps:

1. **Size.** A swarm of creatures increases One Size Stage from their usual size upon merging.
 - a. **Example.** A medium-sized group of creatures becomes a **Large** size after converting to a swarm.
2. **Hit Points.** A swarm of creatures pools their HP together, sharing it until they are reduced to 0.
 - a. **Example.** A group of four creatures, each with 10 HP, would have a total of **40 shared HP.**
3. **To Hit Bonus.** For every two creatures present in the swarm, an additional +1 is added to the baseline To Hit Bonus.
 - a. **Example.** A creature's To Hit Bonus is +5. After merging, the swarm has **four** total creatures. Pair One (+1) plus Pair Two (+1) plus Original Bonus (+5). The **final To Hit Bonus equals +7.**
4. **Attack Damage.** For every two creatures present in the swarm, an additional +1 is added to the **damage dice AND additional damage.**
 - a. **Example.** Assuming four total creatures in a swarm, two pairs (+1 for each pair).
 - i. **Damage Dice:** A creature's Dice=2d4 baseline. After upgrading, the swarm's dice=4d4.
 - ii. **Extra Damage:** A creature's damage=+2 baseline. After upgrading, the damage=+4.
 - iii. **Combined:** a simple attack goes from baseline **2d4+2 to 4d4+4.**

That covers the basics! Once you adjust these stats, you can run a group of monsters as a singular swarm in a shared space. I myself did a test run of how quickly I could upgrade a monster's basics in a swarm: **roughly one minute.** That is minimal time to adjust and saves everyone the headache normal separated summons. But what about a monster's non-basic abilities?



Beyond the Basics

It is highly likely that a monster's statblock may have unique features that are difficult to "scale" with the increased numbers of a swarm. These abilities are murky...meaning there is not an algorithm that can clearly apply to every situation. A Dungeon Master's best friend must be used: professional judgement!

Example Circumstances

Let's say that a player has summoned a group of four **Crag Cats**. These beasts have the ability to pounce, forcing a saving throw or knocking a target prone. Additionally, a prone target can be targeted by a bonus action bite attack. There are a number of conundrums here:

1. Do you have a player make multiple saving throws in a single turn?
2. Does each unique Crag Cat get an extra bonus action attack?
3. Does the change in size affect the distance traveled needed to pounce?

The answers to these questions are murky. As a Dungeon Master, I highly recommend that **you choose the simplest answer** when crafting a swarm statblock. Here is an example of how the above questions would be answered:

1. One saving throw, which has the same scaling on the DC as the basic rules applied before.
2. One bonus action attack that uses the buffed basic attack.
3. No change in the distance needed in order to enact a pounce maneuver.

It is not perfect, but it keeps the statblock consistent with previously established rules while also letting the beast maintain its unique ability!

Swarm Specific Abilities

Finally, you can add in core swarm attributes that should be present for every statblock made. These features allow swarms to feel mechanically unique while simultaneously sparking the imagination of facing down a horde of monsters. Here are the core attributes:

1. **Shared Space.** The swarm can occupy another creature's space and vice versa. It also can fit through any opening large enough for the creature's solo size (Large swarm=medium opening).
2. **Healing Limits.** The swarm can't regain hit points or gain temporary hit points.
3. **Damage Cutoff.** Damage is reduced by half if the swarm has half of its hit points or fewer.
4. **Inherent Attributes.** Abilities, like *Spider Climb*, carry over from individual monster statblock to the swarm statblock.

You now have all you need to create quick swarms on your own! The benefits of swarms are simple: they feel more threatening and are more efficient in a combat setting. Here is a summary of the steps to achieve this:

Step One. Buff the basics to scale your swarm appropriately.

Step Two. Add features beyond the basics that make your individual monster unique.

Step Three. Apply swarm-specific traits to make your swarm feel like a true horde.

Putting it all together is not easy. Chapter Three gives a concrete example on how to put this into practice!

Chapter Three

Putting into Practice

Now that we have a system, we can practice quickly adjusting a statblock to become a swarm. A great example would be the **Wolf** enemy from the 5th Edition SRD. Let's practice with a swarm of **Four Wolves**. The following points would be important to adjust:

1. **Hit Points.** 11 per wolf.
2. **Damage.** +4 to hit, 2d4+2 per attack.
3. **Size.** Currently Medium.
4. **Special Abilities.**
 - a. Pack Tactics
 - b. DC 11 Save to Knock Prone
5. **Swarm-Specific Traits.** None

A final "Swarm Statblock" would look at these points and adjust them according to our algorithm. Here is what the adjustments would lead to :

1. **Hit Points.** 11 HP x 4 wolves = **44 HP.**
2. **Damage.**
 - a. +4 and +1 per pair = **+6 to hit**
 - b. 2d4+2 and +1 per pair = **4d4+4**
3. **Size.** Adjusted to **Large Swarm of Beasts.**
4. **Special Abilities.**
 - a. **Pack Tactics:** permanently active.
 - b. **Save:** 11 +1 per pair = **DC 13**
5. **Swarm-Specific Traits.**
 - a. Shared Space
 - b. Healing Limit
 - c. Damage Cutoff
 - d. Inherent Attributes (e.g. Keen Hearing and Smell)

WOLF

Medium beast, unaligned **New Size=Large**

Armor Class 13 (Natural Armor)

Hit Points ~~11 (2d8+2)~~ **New HP=44**

Speed 40 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
12 (+1)	15 (+2)	12 (+1)	3 (-4)	12 (+1)	6 (-2)

Skills Perception +3, Stealth +4

Senses passive Perception 13

Challenge 1/4 (50 XP)

Add Swarm-Specific Traits Here

Keen Hearing and Smell. The wolf has advantage on Wisdom (Perception) checks that rely on hearing or smell. **Carries Over**

Pack Tactics. The wolf has advantage on an attack roll against a creature if at least one of the wolf's allies is within 5 ft. of the creature and the ally isn't incapacitated. **Permanently Active**

ACTIONS **New Bite=+6 to hit, Hit: (4d4+4) piercing Damage, DC=13 Strength Saving Throw**

Bite. Melee Weapon Attack: ~~+4 to hit~~, reach 5 ft., one target. ~~Hit: (2d4 + 2)~~ piercing damage. If the target is a creature, it must succeed on a ~~DC 11~~ Strength saving throw or be knocked prone

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